‘What use is this job if I can’t attend to my suffering child’, laments a harassed Goa police chief Kiran Bedi, who is accused of absenting herself from duty once the CHOGM retreat responsibilities were over.

On learning that her child, Guchu, was suffering from acute kidney infection, Mrs Bedi proceeded on 15 days’ leave from 5 December [1983]. Since then she has been at her child’s bedside in the Capital.

A former Delhi Traffic police chief, Kiran Bedi was posted to Goa in March last year [1983]. She says: ‘Even then I had to rush back to the Capital as the child had developed kidney problem.’

This time, she claims, Goa Inspector-General Rajendra Mohan had sanctioned her leave initially for 15 days and later extended it on the ground that the child required constant attention.

When asked about the explanation the Goa administration had demanded of her, she described the case as ‘unique in which the IG sanctions the leave of a senior police officer and the State administration cancels it’.

Medical Report

‘No mother would ever tell a lie about her child’s illness … I have sent them medical reports and certificates only to make them realise the gravity of the situation,’ adds Mrs Bedi, who is in a dilemma whether to resume duty or attend to the suffering child.

Guchu is suffering from ‘nephritis’ and is undergoing homoeopathy treatment, while the medical examinations are conducted both by the AIIMS and the Willingdon Hospital [now called Dr Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital].

When is she expected to resume duty?

‘Whenever my child is fully recovered … I have sent a personal letter to the IG and a detailed explanation to the Goa administration about the circumstances in which I am on leave.’

She says that during the eleven years of her service, this was the only occasion when she went on leave. ‘Otherwise my leave always lapses … There is plenty of leave in my account.’

Ever since she proceeded on leave on 5 December last, there has been no objection from the Goa administration and she presumed that her leave had been sanctioned. ‘I am not absenting myself from the duty … I am on leave for which I am entitled.’

(*Patriot*, 30 January 1984)

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For six months Kiran was not given any assignment. Whatever she may have thought about this sudden void in her career, it certainly gave her plenty of time to spend with her daughter and to bring her back to a normal, stable condition. It was only during this stage that she sought an audience with the then Union Home Secretary T. N. Chaturvedi. He lent a sympathetic ear to what she had to say and had her posted to the Railway Protection Force (RPF) as an assistant inspector general of police at the headquarters in New Delhi.

Kiran was extremely relieved on leaving this position, short of six months. She recalls her stint here as follows: ‘Since I was in the headquarters dealing with personnel matters and directly assisting the director-general, a number of rank officers who had a grievance would come to see me. I